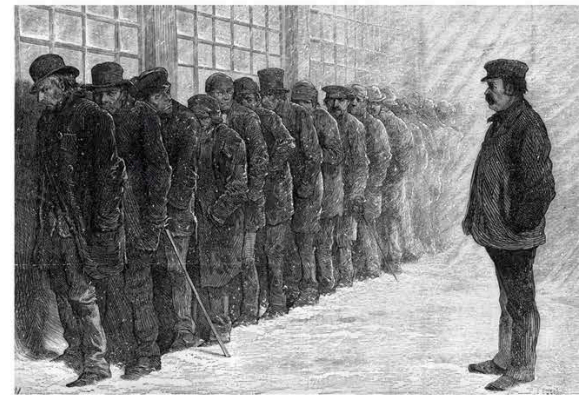
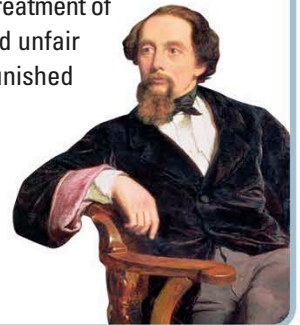




CHARLES DICKENS

Charles Dickens (1812–1870), was the most popular novelist of 19th-century Britain. His books were entertaining but also focused on the social problems of the day, such as the terrible conditions in city slums, bad treatment of children, and unfair laws that punished the poor.



▲ WORKHOUSES

Unemployed poor people, including widows, orphans, and the old or sick, were forced into workhouses (known as poorhouses in the US). Most were expected to work for their shelter and food. Some workhouses were well run, but in many the conditions were terrible. Families were split up and people were often treated no better than prisoners.



▲ IMPROVED SANITATION

In the 19th century, it was common for human waste to end up in rivers, which caused disease because rivers were also used for drinking and washing. In 1858, British engineer Joseph Bazalgette (center) designed a groundbreaking new sewage system in London, which diverted filthy water into underground brick tunnels and away from where people lived.

CHANGING CITIES ►

By the late 19th century, advances in the use of electricity helped improve life in cities. Electricity powered streetcars, and bright electric street lighting helped make city streets safer. In London, the first underground rail line was opened in 1863, providing transportation to a larger number of people.

